



Marc Chagall,
Bridges over the Seine,
 1954 44 x 64 in (112 x 163 cm)
 Chagall's painting demonstrates how color establishes a particular mood or atmosphere. Above the cool dark city hovers a magenta and purple bird that seems to provide a haven for the woman and her child. The orange-red of these figures supported within the bird's wings generates a warm focal point for the work. Below, in the cool, calm blue of the foreground, a couple sleeps beneath this bright vision. The green goat, adjacent to the blue and complementing the magenta, provides a color link between all the components of the composition, and the harmony of strong colors is intensified by the dark background.

The color harmony in this detail is created by using colors that are adjacent to one another on the color wheel.



Philip Sutton, RA,
P.S. as Don Quixote, c.1989 27 x 27 in (70 x 70 cm)
 Sutton has retained a clarity and purity of color in this work by having made clear decisions before painting about where particular colors will go. The lack of overpainting also keeps the colors clean. The painting relies on flat shapes rather than three-dimensional forms to keep the image strong: the bold blue shape defining the hair and beard encloses the complementary orange-reds of the face. This intensifies the color in the face and separates it from the background color, making it a focal point. It also contrasts with the bird in red and yellow, perched delicately on the man's hat.



Elaine Halden, Mushrooms 18 x 20½ in (46 x 53 cm)
 This low-key study is painted with a subdued palette, yet it retains a fresh appearance. The vegetables are painted sparingly, while a hint of pink in the garlic and ochre in the mushrooms add subtlety to the color effect. The white circle of the plate gives the work a slightly formal quality.

Bernadette Kerr, Scalinata 33½ x 37¼ in (85 x 96 cm)
 The soft, almost abstract, forms in this painting are created with a limited range of warm ochres and terra-cottas and cool, muted blue-greens. Colors are unsaturated and used opaquely, and in some areas they have been mixed with white to produce a range of pale, low-key tints.